



FROM THE CARDINAL'S PROMISE

The First 30 Days of Grief

A gentle companion for the heaviest weeks — not a plan to fix anything, just something to hold onto.

There is no right way to grieve, and no schedule you are failing to keep. Grief is not a problem to solve. This is a gentle companion for the first month, when even small things feel impossibly heavy. Take only what helps, and leave the rest.

The first few days

- ☐ Let other people carry things. Say yes when someone offers a specific help.
- ☐ Eat something small and drink water, even when you don't want to.
- ☐ Keep one notebook for the calls, forms, and names you won't remember later.
- ☐ Decide what can wait. Almost everything can.
- ☐ Tell one person, "I just need you to sit with me" — and let them.

The first weeks

- ☐ Expect grief in waves, not stages. A good hour is not a betrayal.
- ☐ Lower the bar for yourself everywhere. "Enough" is the goal, not "well."
- ☐ Notice what soothes you — a walk, a song, a window — and return to it.
- ☐ Set gentle limits on who you update; ask one person to share news for you.
- ☐ If sleep, eating, or getting up becomes impossible for days, reach for support.

What grief often feels like (and it's normal)

- ☐ Numbness, or feeling nothing at all, and then everything at once.
- ☐ Forgetting words, losing time, walking into rooms for no reason.
- ☐ Anger, relief, guilt — sometimes in the same minute. None of it means you loved them less.
- ☐ Looking for them: a face in a crowd, reaching for the phone, listening for the door.
- ☐ Comfort in signs — a cardinal at the window, a familiar song on the radio.

Gentle ways to remember

- ☐ Light a candle at the same time each evening, even briefly.
- ☐ Write them a letter you never have to send.
- ☐ Keep one small object where you'll see it.
- ☐ Say their name out loud. They are allowed to still be part of your days.

When to reach for more support

- ☐ If you have thoughts of not wanting to be here, tell someone today. In the US, call or text 988, any time.
- ☐ If the fog doesn't lift at all after several weeks, a grief counselor can help.
- ☐ Consider a grief support group; being among people who understand eases the loneliness.

Healing is not forgetting, and moving forward is not leaving them behind. You carry them with you. That is allowed.

— The Cardinal's Promise

Want a companion for the longer road? The Cardinal's Promise sits with you in it, and the newsletter sends gentle notes along the way.